

Design Document for *State of ENTROPY*

Caterwaul Studio

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Project Description

State of ENTROPY is a 3D, sci-fi, cosmic, stalker horror game. In *State of Entropy*, the player must navigate through their deteriorating spaceship while avoiding the looming threat of an otherworldly being. Set in a zero-gravity environment where control is limited, the player is forced to adapt to an unnatural and disorienting world. Throughout the game, you're accompanied by your AI companion, Alan, who was disabled during the events leading up to your awakening. Now restricted in his capabilities, Alan must work with you to uncover what happened to the ship's stability and its crew, as you gradually reconnect him across the vessel.

Design Pillars

Overview

1. "Physics-based, zero-gravity movement"
2. "Challenging environmental puzzles"
3. "Relentless pursuing threat"

Pillar 1 - Zero Gravity Aesthetic

Inspired by real-world spacecraft such as the International Space Station, **ENTROPY** commits fully to a 100% zero-gravity look and feel. Player movement is entirely physics-based. Weighty and realistic. Traversing corridors by grabbing handholds, pushing off surfaces, and throwing oneself through space.

This unconventional movement challenges players to think spatially and creatively, enabling exploration in all directions and encouraging emergent solutions through mastery of momentum and positioning. However, in an effort to mitigate visual confusion and motion sickness. Pathways are maintained as long corridors, with multiple environmental anchors to ground the player regularly. Landmarks, communal rooms designed with dedicated floors, and consistent use of text on walls consistently recontextualize spaces for the player. Giving them a more confident understanding of their surroundings.

Pillar 2 - 3D Puzzle Platformer

As players explore the ghost ship, they encounter critical systems that have malfunctioned. Each level presents interconnected environmental puzzles that require investigation, diagnosis, and repair.

These challenges form elaborate, multi-step puzzles, with contextual hints provided by the player's companion AI, **Alan**, who helps guide, but never solve, the player's problems, exploration, observation, and experimentation are key to survival.

Pillar 3 - Stalker Horror Gameplay

While the player focuses on repairs, a hostile alien entity stalks the ship, lurking in darkness and waiting for moments of vulnerability. The creature functions as a persistent environmental threat, dynamically interfering with player objectives and escalating tension with its intelligent hunting strategies. Its movement is free moving, with the ability to phase through unpowered walls, placing it superior to the environment. Utilizing the players obscured sightlines due to the automatic doors. The Geist masks its movements. Inching closer and closer, until the player floats into their traps.

The player is powerless to confront the creature directly. Survival depends on creativity. Using the environment, movement, and spatial awareness to evade, distract, and outmaneuver this terrifying foe.

Core Gameplay Loop

ENTROPY, establishing itself as stalker horror, takes strong inspiration from the game loops of other popular genre titles. While offering new elements to engage the player further. For each level, the game loop follows this fundamental structure:

- The player enters a new environment, searching for the first Alan terminal to reconnect. Going through a contained 3D maze to reach it. Sometimes the Geist will appear to chase the player. Phasing through unpowered walls to corner and capture them.
- Once the first Alan terminal is connected, game saved, this establishes the player's starting point/ hub for the level. All powered sections of the ship establish safe zones from the Geist. Who cannot phase through electrical fields.
- Alan gives establishing information for the area. Hinting at the level puzzle, a system malfunction in this sector of the ship that the player must repair.

- The player continues to explore, picking up on environmental clues, engaging with new mechanics, and gathering data logs; priming them for the level puzzle and providing narrative background. All the while continuing to relink more Alan terminals, saving games, receiving inferences from Alan. But it is up to the player to figure it out.
 - Once the player is properly prepared, they finally venture to diagnose the system malfunction, and apply the proper repairs. However, large sounds attract the Geist.
 - Once the Geist appears, the player must utilize stealth, and misdirection tactics to evade. If they don't they will be killed. They must get back to a powered section. Safe again, for now.
 - The malfunction is fixed, all Alan terminals are back online. The player has successfully fixed the section. On to the next.
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Feature List

- Zero Gravity Movement
 - Narrative-Driven Gameplay
 - AI Stalker Enemy
 - Intractable Zero Gravity Environment
 - Digital Age Cassette Futurist Aesthetic
 - PS3 Inspired Graphics
 - Spatial Audio Effects
 - Composed Official Soundtrack
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Mechanics/Interfaces/Functionality

Zero Gravity Movement Controller

Players will engage with a first-person Zero Gravity movement system. Players will intentionally feel a sense of unease and lack of control. Players will experience a lack of friction, directional control, and often unclear positioning within the environment, similar to real zero gravity. To navigate this unstable environment, players will need to grab onto movement aid bars and launch themselves forward, traversing from bar to bar across the ship [right click + WASD]. While in Zero Gravity, the player is able to rotate themselves around their forward axis [q or e], reorienting themselves to a direction that best suits their ease of navigation. Players also possess the ability to interact with objects throughout the ship.

The Geist

The Geist is *ENTROPY'S* stalker enemy; it is introduced to the player through a scripted cutscene towards the end of level 1. Over the course of level 2, the player will run into it as it roams around the environment, eventually triggering a chase scene where The Geist will fully reveal itself to the player.

Narratively, The Geist has isolated the player character in her own ship, seeing her as a novel test subject to poke and prod at. Design-wise, The Geist is an amalgam of several species of deep sea Jellyfish and common flowers. The Geist is the 3D avatar of a 4D being, it being based in the fourth dimension means that it will frequently phase through walls to chase the player around levels.

In select areas of level 2, players will be introduced to controllable doors and electric fields that will stop or slow The Geist's pursuit of them. Environment puzzles will utilize this mechanic, forcing players to experiment with different combinations of closed doors and electrified fields to outmaneuver The Geist.

Alan

Alan is the ship's on-board AI system; it controls the ship's systems and environment, but its access has been cut. Alan runs the player through the tutorial and gives objectives that will take the player around the environments of each level. Once Alan's connection is restored to an area of the ship, it will be able to see and speak to the player, guiding them forward and responding to completed tasks with new information and objectives. Alan has no true intentions, only moods and behaviors dictated by the narrative, giving developers direct control over pacing and tension. Through the reconnection of Alan terminals, the environment itself comes back online: lights, doors, A.I.D. stations, saves, and other automated systems hum to life after reconnection. This makes Alan feel like the armature of the ship, guiding the player through objectives and allowing them to tangibly change the environment, even if only through a proxy.

Wrist Monitor

The wrist monitor acts as the player's primary information hub, brought into view with [Tab] and defaulting to the last opened screen. It provides access to objectives, a live-updating map, and a file directory through side-mounted buttons. The objectives tab displays player vitals and the current goal, with an option to review completed objectives. The map defaults to an orthographic view with simple controls for switching views, zooming, and recentering on the player, while also allowing a transition into a full-screen perspective mode via the map tab. In perspective view, the map updates in real time, freely pans with mouse input, and automatically aligns to the player's position and orientation to support navigation. The file directory allows collected files to be reviewed through preview pages, reinforcing exploration and narrative discovery.

Environment Dangers

Pipe Breaches: Pipe Breaches are the result of internal damage to the ship's pressure system, which has caused localized maintenance pipes to explode and corrode surrounding areas. The pressure system, unstable within these areas, frequently activates and deactivates, causing intense pressure to be expelled outwards. Getting hit with this highly pressurized gas will cause the player to be pushed in the corresponding direction with intense force. It is also very likely to cause head trauma, causing players to take damage.

Malfunctioning Doors: Malfunctioning Doors are a big part of *Entropy's* level design; they limit the areas of the ship available to players and allow for slower, more linear progression through levels. Malfunctioning doors come in two kinds - locked and broken. Locked doors prevent all player interaction, completely blocking certain paths and environments. Broken doors actively slam open and closed, forcing the player to either risk trying to slip between the cracks or get crushed in the process.

Technology Needs

- Unity Engine - version: 6000.1.3f1
- UnityHub
- Unity Package Manager
 - Steam Audio
 - Probuilder
- Blender
- Maya 2026
- ZBrush
- Substance Painter
- Adobe Creative Cloud
 - Illustrator
 - Photoshop
- Ableton Live
- FL Studio
- GitHub repository
- GitHub Desktop
- Miro
- Trello
- Google Drive
 - Docs
 - Sheets
 - Forms
 - Calendars

Time Needed Per Task

- 1 Week Per Task. Larger tasks will be split into achievable weekly tasks.